



to adopt it. Moreover, there is no strategy for one solution that fits all approaches. There are multiple strategies, and each strategy has its own advantages and disadvantages,” explains Mahajan.

A recent report published by Red Hat notes that 90% of IT leaders surveyed are using enterprise open source today, and they are using it for IT infrastructure modernisation (64%), application development (54%), and digital transformation (53%). The move to remote working, as per the report, forced many organisations to accelerate their digital transformation efforts to maintain innovation and continue to meet customer demands. So it makes sense that it moved up this year to the top three.

Paul Cormier, President and CEO, Red Hat, in the report says, “Open source has solidified itself as an innovation engine for the software industry. The technology trends that you see changing how we work and do business were born in open source—enterprise Linux, cloud computing, edge and the Internet of Things (IoT), containers, artificial intelligence and machine learning, and DevOps. These are the same principles that apply to how you’ve seen the world come together and make rapid advancements, like the Covid vaccine, in a shorter time frame than ever before. In both cases, enterprise technology and the challenges of a Covid world, the problems are too big for one person, one company, or one organisation to solve.”

He adds, “But it’s in moments like this where open source truly shows its power. Collaboration, transparency, and the idea that the best idea can come from anywhere are the principles that help organisations not just meet challenges but reach new heights.”

Assessing open source adoption

Assessing the adoption rate of open source is not an easy task to accom-

What all should be assessed in the cost factor

- Implementation and deployment cost
- Development cost
- Support cost
- Subscription cost
- Training cost

plish as different industries use open source solutions for different reasons. For instance, a manufacturer might be using open source software for collecting data generated by machines to accomplish better turnover whereas an e-commerce player might be using open source software to enable search on his platform, so on and so forth. The cost of ownership and the risks associated also vary from case to case.

“Open source solutions and their sustainability need to be adopted on case to case basis, keeping unbiased risk assessment in focus,” says Mahajan.

The industries and verticals where the open source solutions are being adopted today include infrastructure software, application development, DevOps, databases, analytics, and cloud based operations. There are a lot of open source stacks available for all these verticals. Most of the new databases, as a matter of fact, are open source. There is no vertical left in cloud based solutions where open source cannot play a major role. But the question for organisations looking to deploy open source solutions remains the same. Why should they do so?

The beginning to the answer of this questions lies within the organisations themselves. What are the parameters they have kept in focus while assessing if they should go for open source solutions or not? The parameters that should generally be kept in focus while looking towards open source solutions include, but are not limited to, cost, freedom

and flexibility, maturity, and talent retention.

“All these criteria might not be relevant to all the organisations. For some, all of these might be relevant, for others, only a few of these might be relevant,” says Mahajan.

Cost as a criteria

Whether an individual or an organisation is investing in a new building, or a new software, the cost involved plays a critical role. The importance of the cost factor, while deploying an open source solution, increases by leaps and bounds. Cost of an open source solution is not limited to the cost incurred in downloading and installing a solution but also the cost the company will pay for the support services required for that solution.

“Any organisation looking for open source adoption should look at the long term cost of the open source solution. You will need support for the solution down the road. If you do not opt for that support, the only choice you may end up with is to stop using that solution and throwing it away,” explains Mahajan.

This could be a point where the senior management could raise questions and ask why this was not given a thought while choosing the solution. The key towards assessing and choosing an open source solution lies in calculating costs for at least five years down the road. The aspects to keep in mind include costs required for installing and maintaining the solution, the costs saved using the solution, and the cost of manpower required for the solution.

One should also keep in mind where further development of the solution will take place in-house, or will the organisation hire a third-party to do so. Further, deploying an open source solution mostly requires paying a support cost to a third party that can support the solution in the long run.